Pentecost and the First Church

Acts 1–2 · Acts 4:32–37

The big idea: The risen Jesus sent the Holy Spirit, a Person and fully God, to live in his people. At Pentecost the gospel was preached in many languages and three thousand were baptized. The church grows by ordinary means: God's word, the sacraments, and prayer, lived out together.

Before you meet: Read

Acts 1:4–11 | Acts 2:1–24 | Acts 2:36–47

Open (5 minutes)

Think of a group you belonged to that felt like family. What made it feel that way?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"Repent and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the _____ of your sins." *(Acts 2:38)*

"And they devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and the _____, to the breaking of bread and the prayers." *(Acts 2:42)*

"And divided tongues as of _____ appeared to them and rested on each one of them." *(Acts 2:3)*

Discuss

1. Jesus said it was to their advantage that he go away. Why would having the Spirit be better than having Jesus physically present? *John 16:7; John 14:16–17*

2. The crowd asked, What shall we do? What did Peter tell them, and what does that mean for you? *Acts 2:37–39*

3. Which of the four marks in Acts 2:42 is strongest in your life? Which is weakest? *Acts 2:42–47*

Memory verse

> *"And they devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers."*
>
> **Acts 2:42**

Pray

Thank God for pouring out his Spirit on his people. Ask him to make you devoted to his word, to his people, to the Lord's Supper, and to prayer. Pray by name for one person you want to hear the gospel, and ask for boldness to speak.

LEADER NOTES · WEEK 45

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Session plan (about 45 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Acts 2:1–4 and 2:36–47 aloud together.
5 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
20 min	Discuss: choose three of the questions.
5 min	Pray together. Introduce the memory verse and next week's reading (Acts 3–8 and 10–12).

Main points to land

1. The Holy Spirit is a Person, fully God with the Father and the Son, sent by the risen Christ to dwell in his people (John 14:16–17; Acts 2:33; WSC 6).
2. At Pentecost the Spirit came, the gospel was preached in many languages, and three thousand repented and were baptized. The promise is for you and for your children (Acts 2:1–41).
3. The church grows by ordinary means: God's word, the sacraments, and prayer, lived out in fellowship (Acts 2:42; WSC 88).

Core doctrine to teach

Baptism CORE DOCTRINE 23 OF 26

Baptism is the sign Jesus commanded for his people: washing with water in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit. It marks a person as belonging to Christ and joins them to his church. The water itself does not save. Christ saves, and baptism is his visible sign and promise of cleansing and new life in him. *Matthew 28:19; Acts 2:38–41; Romans 6:3–4*

Answer key (Observe)

1. forgiveness
2. fellowship
3. fire

Questions people will ask

Does Acts 2:38 mean baptism saves you?

No. Forgiveness comes through faith in Christ alone (Acts 10:43; 16:31). Baptism is the sign and seal God gives to his people, and Peter calls them to receive it together with repentance, because it pictures the forgiveness Christ gives. The water does not save, but Christ, whom it signifies, does (WSC 94).

Closing prayer

Lord Jesus, you poured out your Spirit on your people and built your church. Fill us with your Spirit. Make us devoted to your word, to one another, to your table, and to prayer. Give us boldness to speak of what we have seen and heard, and send your word to the people we love. Amen.